

of Things is not just many devices in the home, but the whole home as an intelligent device.

Nest Learning Thermostat

The Nest Learning Thermostat made headlines in 2014 when it was launched. It garnered the interest of computing giant Google and has since made a significant impact in the market place. The device while being a simple thermostat is indicative of the predictive nature of home technology. The device is made to learn the needs of the people in the household and regulate itself to provide the most comfortable environment possible. The company also connects with energy companies where such links are possible and ensures efficiency in energy consumption. The thermostat is created with an easy to use and intuitive interface which can also be remotely operated. So users can monitor and alter their home environment while they're on their way home. The unique aspect is its self-learning feature which is able to determine the minimal energy to comfort ratio and tune the environment accordingly. It takes into account airflow, weather and other personal preferences to do its job. The company has already made moves to broaden its range and is expected to introduce more devices in the near future.

Amazon Echo

The Amazon Echo is like a voice controlled system which interacts with people. It functions by connecting to the internet and using voice recognition technology to answer queries. In many ways, it is the household equivalent of a Siri or Google Now. The design of the device is a simple cylinder that also has the ability to play music on command. The technology behind it is rooted on cloud based processing which allows it to respond to natural language queries. The device can also be used to make notes such as shopping lists, play radio, set alarms and even access Wikipedia. One of its next generation features is its ability to interface with a few other sensor driven home devices like the Belkin WeMo.

In addition to these high profile consumer-end products there is a vast marketplace of home automation devices. Although this market segment is highly specialised it still doesn't as of yet leverage the Internet of Things to accomplish its goal of home automation. While we will be discussing a few of these companies in later chapters we need to remember that the difference between smart devices and intelligent devices is the degree and depth of the interconnectivity and software applications. 